

Preparing Spells with Metamagic (Prepared Casters)

This guide explains how a prepared caster (Wizard, Cleric, Druid) applies metamagic feats while preparing spells, and how that flow is implemented in the prototype.

Rules basis (D&D 3.5e, PHB p.88): A prepared spellcaster chooses metamagic at the time of preparation. A metamagic-enhanced spell occupies a slot of the spell's adjusted level (base level + the feat's level adjustment) and is cast in the normal casting time. (Quicken Spell is the exception — it changes casting time, not slot rules, but still raises the slot level.)

The player flow, step by step

1. **Open Spell Preparation.** This screen appears during pre-combat preparation (resting / morning). Each available spell slot is shown as its own row, grouped and labeled by level (e.g. `Level 3 Slot 1:`).
2. **Find the slot you want to fill.** The slot level is fixed by the row — a `Level 3 Slot` row can only hold something whose effective level is 3.
3. **Open that row's dropdown.** The dropdown lists, for that exact slot level:
 - `(Empty)` — leave the slot unprepared.
 - **Normal spells** of that level you know (e.g. `Fireball`).
 - ⚡ **Metamagic options** — lower-level spells you know, already combined with metamagic feats your character has, where the math lands exactly on this slot's level.
4. **Pick a ⚡ option to apply metamagic.** Each metamagic option spells out the math, for example:

⚡ Empowered Magic Missile (lvl 1 +2 → lvl 3)

This reads as: Base spell Magic Missile (1st level) + Empower Spell (+2 levels) = a 3rd-level slot — which is exactly the slot you are filling.

1. **Confirm Preparation.** The slot now holds the metamagic-enhanced spell. When you cast it in combat it produces the enhanced effect (empowered damage, extended duration, etc.).
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Why a dropdown instead of checkboxes?

For **prepared** casters the slot level is decided before you choose the spell — you are filling a specific slot. So instead of asking you to pick a spell and then

toggle feats and hope the total fits, the UI does the arithmetic for you and only offers combinations that fit the slot exactly. This guarantees:

- You can never prepare a combination that is too big or too small for the slot.
- The adjusted level is always shown up front (`lvl 1 +2 → lvl 3`).
- It is always obvious which slot the metamagic spell will consume — it is the row you opened.

Spontaneous casters (Sorcerer/Bard) work differently: they choose metamagic at cast time and pay with a higher-level slot then. That flow lives in the combat casting UI, not here.

What metamagic options are generated

When a slot row is built (`SpellPreparationUI.CreateSlotRow → option list`), for a non-domain, non-specialist slot above level 0 the UI generates options from every lower-level spell the caster knows, combined with the metamagic feats the caster actually has (`SpellcastingComponent.GetKnownMetamagicFeats()`):

Feat	Level adjustment	Notes
Enlarge Spell	+1	Only spells with a range > 0
Extend Spell	+1	Only spells with a duration
Silent Spell	+1	Any spell
Still Spell	+1	Any spell
Empower Spell	+2	Only spells with numeric (damage/healing) effects
Maximize Spell	+3	Only spells with dice (damage/healing)
Widen Spell	+3	Only area spells
Quicken Spell	+4	Any spell
Heighten Spell	variable	Raises the spell to exactly this slot's level

Generation rules:

- **Single fixed-adjustment feats** — an option appears only when `baseLevel + adjustment == slotLevel`.
- **Heighten Spell** — for any known spell with `baseLevel < slotLevel`, a single option is offered that raises it to exactly `slotLevel` (`HeightenToLevel = slotLevel`).

- **Two-feat combinations** — pairs of fixed-adjustment feats are offered when `baseLevel + adj1 + adj2 == slotLevel` (e.g. Empower + Silent on a 1st-level spell fits a 4th-level slot).
- **Applicability** is checked per feat via `MetamagicData.IsApplicable` (e.g. Empower only on damage/healing spells), so nonsensical combinations never appear.
- **Domain and specialist slots are excluded** — these cannot hold metamagic spells.

Validation (defense in depth)

Even though the dropdown only offers valid combinations, the backend re-validates on preparation in `SpellcastingComponent.PrepareSpellInSlotWithMetamagic` :

- The effective level (`MetamagicData.GetEffectiveSpellLevel(baseLevel)`) must equal the target slot's level, otherwise preparation is rejected.
- Domain / specialist slots reject metamagic.
- The base spell must be in the slot's caster-class spell list.

The effective level is also capped at 9th level (`GetEffectiveSpellLevel`).

Key code references

- `Assets/Scripts/UI/Spells/SpellPreparationUI.cs`
- `CreateSlotRow` / option-list build — generates the per-slot dropdown options.
- `BuildMetamagicOptionLabel` — formats the ⚡ ... (lvl X +Y → lvl Z) labels.
- `OnSlotChanged` — routes a chosen option to the right preparation method.
- `Assets/Scripts/Spell/Components/SpellcastingComponent.cs`
- `GetKnownMetamagicFeats` , `GetKnownSpellsForClass` , `PrepareSpellInSlotWithMetamagic` .
- `Assets/Scripts/Spell/Components/MetamagicData.cs`
- `IsApplicable` , `GetLevelAdjustment` , `GetEffectiveSpellLevel` , `GetDisplayName` (combined adjective name used in labels).